of Southern Africa is rife with self-confessed corruption and incompetence (as Chapter 7 above shows), and the two largest NDB precedents – the Chinese and Brazilian banks – epitomise destructive extractivism, is this really to be welcomed? After all, the largest single World Bank project loan ever (US$3.75 billion) was just four years ago, to abet Pretoria's madcap emergency financing of Medupi (Bond 2014), the biggest coal-fired power plant anywhere in the world now under construction, which will emit more greenhouse gases (35 million tonnes/year) than do 115 individual countries.

In 2013, as Medupi came under intense pressure from community, labour and environmental activists (thus setting back the completion several years behind schedule), World Bank president Jim Yong Kim could no longer justify such climate-frying loans. He pledged withdrawal from the Bank's dirtiest fossil fuel projects. That, in turn, is potentially the gap for an NDB: to carry on filthy-finance once BRICS countries issue securities for dirty mega-projects and can't find Western lenders. For in even the most backward site of struggle, the United States, a growing activist movement is rapidly compelling disinvestment from oil and coal firms and projects (Fossil Free USA 2014). Of course there is a need for a genuinely inclusive and sustainable financial alternative, such as the early version, prior to Brazilian state sabotage, of the Banco del Sur that was catalysed by the late Venezuelan President Hugo Chávez. Launched in Caracas with $7 billion in capital, it has an entirely different mandate and can still be manoeuvred not to 'stabilise' world finance but instead to offer a just alternative (*Andes Info* 2013).

Shaky ground on which to build BRICS from the middle and below

To help BRICS elites end their addiction to the Western model of exclusionary, unsustainable capitalism, a revamped 12-step programme will be necessary. The first two steps of the classic Alcoholic Anonymous programme are obvious enough: 'We admitted we were powerless over alcohol, that our lives had become unmanageable and came to believe that a Power greater than ourselves could restore us to sanity.' The cleansing power of political-economic sanity absent in the BRICS elites comes from only one place: below, i.e. social activism. Against that kind of activism, BRICS from above needs BRICS from the middle: the Civic BRICS strategy Putin adopted in early 2015. The project was banal, and attracted such status quo groups that the Brazilian NGO network Rebrip dropped out entirely. In the Russian government's (2015) own words:

> Civic BRICS is the innovative political process, for the first time to be implemented within BRICS Summit in 2015 … The civil society, rep-